

Q&A

Your Questions, Our Answers

Helpful Warnings

Q I have Windows 2000 Professional installed. Whenever I'm connected to the Internet, a message flashes, stating either that a worm has been detected, or that there's a problem with the Registry. It advises me to visit some Web sites and download Registry repairing software, and says my system will be damaged if I don't. I want to know whether these messages are genuine. I have the latest version of Norton AntiVirus, and it does not detect any viruses.

Debabrata Rout

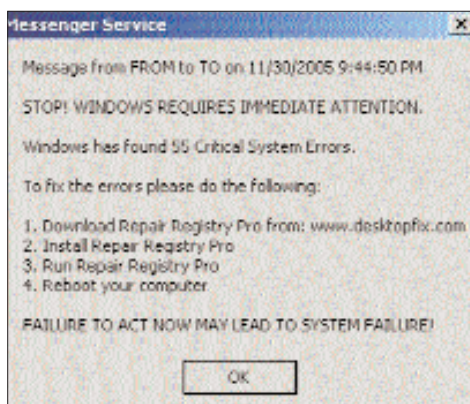
A Your computer is infected not by a virus or worm, but by some form of spyware or adware. Many of these are not detected by anti-virus programs. You need to install anti-spyware software to get rid of these.

Microsoft AntiSpyware from www.microsoft.com and Spybot-S&D from www.safer-networking.org/en/ are good (and free!) anti-spyware applications to start with. Alternatively, you might want use paid anti-spyware applications such as Ad-Aware SE from www.lavasoft.com.

Install one of these programs and update the spyware and adware definitions file from the respective Web site, and thoroughly scan your hard drive for spyware and adware. You might need to install more than one anti-spyware software to remove all spyware or adware applications installed on your computer.

Note that some applications, such as the DivX Create Bundle, require the adware bundled with them to function properly—make sure you're deleting only unnecessary adware!

When you've got spyware on your computer, Windows might display a warning like this one



AGP Blues

Q I have a GeForce2 MX400 64 MB graphics card. My problem is that this AGP card does not support any of the latest games. I updated the BIOS and installed the latest display drivers and DirectX 9.0c. My graphics card BIOS version is 3.11.0124.

Renju R

A The nVidia GeForce2 MX400 chip is DirectX 7 compliant. It does not have the features required to run games written to take advantage of certain features that can only be found in graphics chips supporting higher versions of DirectX. Some such features are Pixel Shaders and Vertex Shaders—most of the newer games use these features, and hence they will not run on this card, unless the game allows running in a lower mode that uses DirectX 7.

Installing DirectX 9.0c and the latest drivers will not solve this problem either. The only remedy is upgrading to a newer AGP graphics card supporting DirectX 9, such as those in the GeForce FX and 6x00 series.

Fine Card, Broken Graphics

Q I have a Pentium III 1 GHz with Windows XP SP2, 256 MB of RAM, and a GeForce4 MX 4000 128 MB with Forceware version 77.72 connected to an AGP 4X slot. I have DirectX 9.0c installed.

In almost all the games I play, the graphics appear broken into triangles—especially text and moving objects. All the settings are at their defaults, and the DxDiag tests all run fine.

I never experienced this problem until recently. I even tried keeping all the graphics settings at their lowest values, but the problem persists.

Aslam Kamal

A The problem you're facing—and also other problems such as texture bleeding, flashing triangles and corrupted textures—often happens due to improper AGP aperture size. The AGP aperture size is memory that has been reserved from your system RAM for graphical processing. This takes the RAM out of use for you and your operating system.

The problem can be remedied by changing the AGP aperture size. You will have to experiment with different values until you find one that suits you.

You can only change the AGP aperture from the BIOS. It can usually be accessed under 'Advanced Chipset Features', depending on the BIOS manufacturer. It can be set to values such as 16, 32, 64, 128 and 256 MB. Different motherboards allow different settings—for example, i815 motherboards will not allow you to set the aperture size above 64 MB. As a rule of thumb, set the value to half your system memory for optimal performance.

The problem you've described can also occur if your graphics card is damaged, in which case you'll have to get yourself a new card.